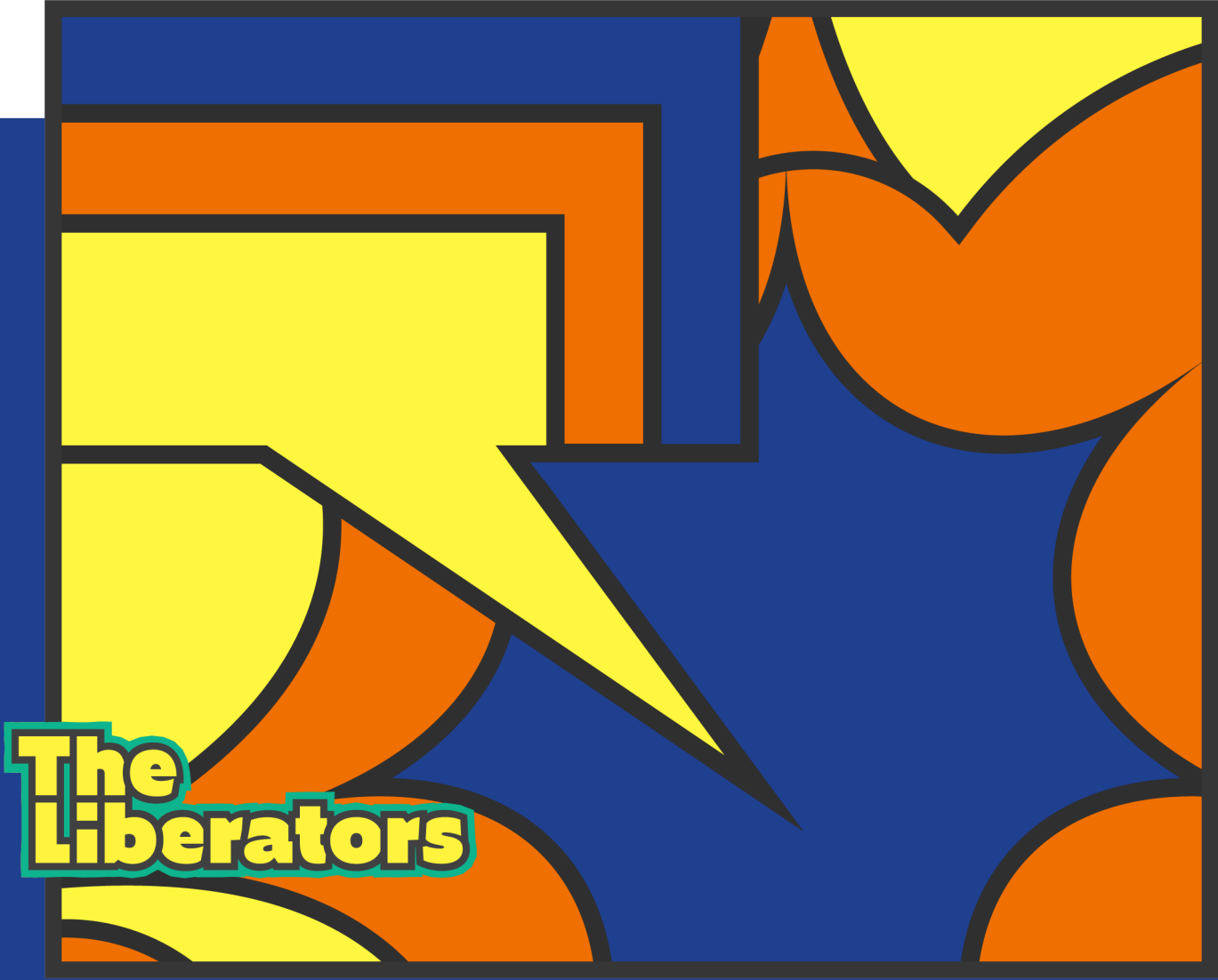


Deepen Your Understanding Of Scrum With Real-Life Cases

Learn more about the Scrum framework and its principles & values through reflection, dialogue, and interaction



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Experiment

The Scrum framework is a lightweight framework to solve complex and adaptive problems. Although it looks easy on paper, it's often much harder to do well in the messiness of the real world. Where do you make trade-offs? How can you model the Scrum values? How can you work empirically in an environment that isn't suited for it?

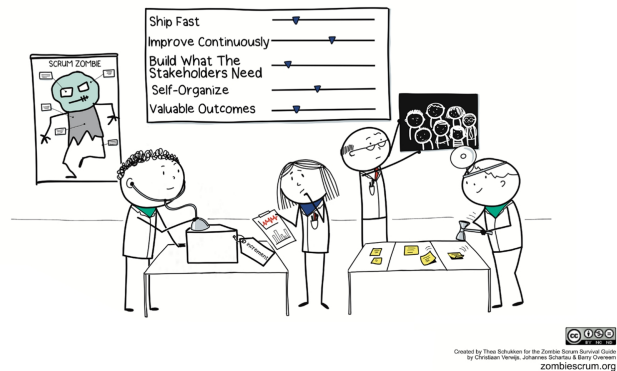
To encourage Scrum practitioners to explore these questions, we created 52 real-life cases. These cases are inspired by our own experiences and those of the people we frequently work with. Use these cases for your community of Scrum Masters, as conversation starters in and around your Scrum team, or put your own understanding of Scrum to the test. And no, there is no "right answer" :) The learning is not in knowing the answer, but in jointly deepening your understanding of the Scrum principles and values through reflection, dialogue, and putting new ideas into practice.

This experiment contains 6 free cases you can immediately use. We offer inspiration for when to use these cases and give suggestions for what Liberating Structures to try as conversation starters. If you consider it useful, you can download [the total package with 52 cases](#) for a small fee in our webshop.

Give it a try and let us know how it went!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment doesn't require special skills. Finding time to discuss the cases might be the biggest challenge.

Impact On Survival



The cases help you gain a deeper understanding of the Scrum framework, and its principles & values.

Example: What Are Good Metrics?



What are good metrics?

You've been working as a Scrum Master for three different Scrum Teams for a while now. The teams all work on the same product, use the same technology, and work for the same group of stakeholders.

Recently, the manager of the teams has asked you to help her identify useful metrics to track their performance. Currently, no metrics are tracked. But she suggested tracking the number of hours worked and the number of items completed per Sprint.

What metrics would you suggest? How does this case connect to the Scrum Values? What else would you do?

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Example: The Technical Sprint Review



The technical Sprint Review

As a Scrum Master, you've been asked to support a Scrum Team that builds an API connector. One of the biggest challenges for this team is their Sprint Review. The team feels that the technical nature of their product makes it impossible to review it with stakeholders. So the Sprint Review usually takes the shape of a status update where the Product Owner's checks of what was done. Stakeholders are not present because nobody invites them.

And in all honesty, the team seems to have a point there. The API connector communicates exclusively with JSON. So the only meaningful thing they can show is JSON messages. And that doesn't mean anything to stakeholders.

Although the Scrum Team wants to improve, they see no way to include the stakeholders in a way that makes good use of their time.

How do you help this team? How does this connect to transparency, inspection, and adaptation? What questions would you ask this team or their stakeholders?

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Example: The Part-Time Scrum Master



What Would You Do?

The part-time Scrum Master

Your web-development shop started with Scrum a year ago. This was an idea raised by the Scrum Teams themselves. Although the founder was receptive to the idea, he asked that the role of the Scrum Master would be fulfilled for eight hours a week at most. Otherwise, the overhead would be too significant.

As a result, in most Scrum Teams, a developer, tester or analyst volunteered to spend eight hours a week acting as a Scrum Master. This time would be used to prepare & facilitate the Scrum events and update the Scrum board. After a while, the teams decided to rotate this responsibility.

A few months down the road, the role of the Scrum Master is brought up during a company-wide Retrospective. It's getting harder and harder to find volunteers.

Imagine attending this Retrospective, what would be a way to demonstrate the value of the Scrum Master? What ideas or suggestions would you raise?

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Example: Management Creates The Scrum Teams



What Would You Do?

Management creates the Scrum Teams

The head of your organization wants to introduce Scrum. Currently, work is organized mostly into functional departments. So there is a department for testing, one for coding and one for architecture and analysis. It has been impressed on management to create cross-functional teams where various skill-sets and specialties are mixed.

As a coach and experienced Scrum Master, the company asks for your help with team formation. The heads of the various departments have already spent a couple of days together to create potential teams. In the process, they've also identified some employees that they are willing to let go of. Their worry is that these employees will resist the change. The department heads have also worked hard to take into interpersonal relationships, skills, personalities and personal ambitions. But they're not happy with the result and are looking for your recommendations. They hope you can offer some quick tips, as time is of the essence and the Scrum Teams need to start in a couple of days.

What recommendations do you have? What are the benefits of the current approach? What are benefits of other approaches? What would be your first step?

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Example: Different Definitions Of Done's



What Would You Do?

Different Definition of Done's

The company you've been working on is scaling up its effort to deliver an upcoming product that processes banking transactions. Plans are to scale from three to ten Scrum Teams, each working on a separate component of the same product. You've been asked to support this process and make sure that it works.

One of the first things you do is host a workshop to develop a Definition of Done with the teams. After going back and forth on this for a while, the teams settle on an approach where each team has their own Definition of Done. This gives each team the greatest flexibility and allows them to get their work done without having to depend on the other teams. Another reason why they think this works well is because each team adheres to different quality standards. Having a shared Definition of Done would be impractical and cause delays.

What are your thoughts? How could this decision impact transparency? If you take the perspective of a stakeholder of this product, what might a consequence be for them?

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Example: "We're Almost There..."



What Would You Do?

"We're almost there"

You are working with a Scrum Team that is doing Scrum to the letter. The team is in its 20th sprint. The Product Backlog is in tip-top shape, the Scrum Events are running smoothly and the Scrum Team has been collaborating effectively to reliably achieve their Sprint Goals. The product is coming together rapidly.

The Product Owner is driven, energetic, and has a strong vision. Being incredibly excited about the product, he has not yet invited any stakeholders to attend the Sprint Review. Although he intends to start doing so soon, he keeps pushing this into the next sprint with the argument: "We're almost there. We just need a couple more features".

How do you respond? Which Scrum values can guide your behavior? How? And how does this connect to empirical process control?

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When To Use The Cases?

Finding a good opportunity to use the Scrum cases shouldn't be too difficult. You can use them for individual reflection, within your Scrum team, or the wider organization. Some specific examples to use the Scrum cases are:

During Sprint Retrospective

Share the Scrum cases before the Sprint Retrospective with your Scrum team. Ask everyone to select the cases they think are the most interesting, relevant, or challenging. Identify the top-3 and bring those cases to the Sprint Retrospective to discuss in more detail.

For individual reflection

Select a Scrum case, get your own thinking started, and share your thoughts on LinkedIn. Most likely, it will trigger a conversation in which you can explore the case with other Scrum practitioners.

Within your Community of Practice

Many organizations have a Community of Practice in which participants share experiences and give & get help. Organize a session with the most relevant Scrum cases as a topic.

As a conversation starter with management

Share the Scrum cases with management in your organization. Ask them to identify the most challenging cases or the one that raises the most questions. Simply have a one-on-one conversation with a manager about a specific case. Or host a workshop with more managers to discuss the cases.

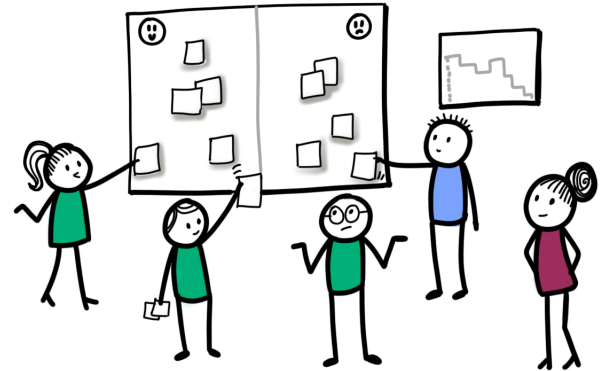
During a public meetup

Make a specific Scrum case the topic for a public meetup. For example, your local Scrum user group. The wide variety of experiences will offer many different, fresh, and surprising perspectives.

For a job interview

Use the cases for any kind of Scrum-related job interview. Prepare a couple of cases, ask the candidate to select the one (s)he considers the most interesting, challenging, or recognizable and simply have a conversation. By discussing the case you'll get a good sense of the person's understanding of the Scrum framework.

SPRINT RETROSPECTIVE



Created by Thies Reubben for the ZenHub Scrum Survival Guide by Christiaan Veejis, Johannes Schabus & Barry Oomsen

Part 1 - How To Use The Cases?



We purposefully wrote each case in such a way that there is no clear "right" answer. Instead, there are different sides to each case, different arguments to make, and different solutions — some better than others. Just like the real world ...

For the best learning experience, use Liberating Structures to structure the conversation. That way, everyone can offer their perspective. You may even find creative solutions to your own challenges!

Some examples of Liberating Structures to try are:

Conversation Cafe

We like to use Conversation Cafe to dig into cases like these. It encourages people to listen and understand each other's perspectives on a profound, shared topic or challenge instead of trying to convince or persuade others to see it your way. Sitting in a circle with a simple set of agreements and a talking object, small groups engage in consecutive rounds of dialogue. Follow-up with 15% Solutions or 1–2–4–ALL to translate learnings from the case to your own team or environment.

1–2–4–ALL

Only doing a 1–2–4–ALL during a session is already a good approach to explore a case. Start with 1 minute of silent self-reflection. Take 2 minutes to generate ideas in pairs, building on ideas from self-reflection. Create groups of four and use 4 minutes to share and develop ideas that you've discussed within your pair. Notice similarities and differences. Take 5 minutes to share insights, ideas, and takeaways.

Impromptu Networking

With Impromptu Networking, you can discuss a case within 15 minutes. Invite the participants to stand up and form pairs. Present the case to discuss. Within the pairs, ask people to share their answers to the case. Signal the end of the first round and have people from new pairs. Within the new pairs, ask people to (again) share their answers. But also ask them to pay attention to similarities and differences from their previous conversation. Do one more round. After the 3 rounds, gather insights and patterns that the participants noticed.

User Experience Fishbowl

The UX Fishbowl is ideally suited for unleashing the local wisdom of groups of any size. If within your team or organization people have experience (successes or failures) with a certain case, invite them to participate as the "inner circle" of the fishbowl. During the UX Fishbowl, the inner circle shares experiences while the outer circles listen. In alternating rounds, the outer circles generate questions they'd like to ask the inner circle. By focusing strongly on listening and asking questions about experiences, you can use UX Fishbowls to create an environment where people can learn together (rather than get solutions imposed on them).

Shift & Share

Especially in larger groups, Shift & Share is an ideal structure to discuss one or multiple cases. Prepare 4–6 stations with each a specific case. Ask the group to form small teams and to pick one station. At their station, the teams discuss the case and write feedback on the flip-over. After 10 minutes, the teams move clockwise to the next station. This is repeated until the teams have visited all stations. Discuss the key takeaways with the group as a whole.



Part 2 - How To Use The Cases?



Other Liberating Structures to consider are:

Discovery & Action Dialogue

"Discovery & Action Dialogue" (DAD) exists to help groups invent local solutions to the problems they face. Rather than giving up or immediately reaching to "best practices" that worked elsewhere, it helps groups carefully analyze the problem, potential solution, and how everyone can contribute to both. To use "Discovery & Action Dialogue", select the most challenging case for your team or organization, download this worksheet, and discuss the questions in small groups.

Wicked Questions

Especially because there are no right answers, the Liberating Structure Wicked Questions is ideally suited to discuss the cases. The purpose of Wicked Questions is not to find a single answer, but to create transparency about seemingly paradoxical realities that exist side-by-side. By accepting both realities, you can engage in deeper strategic thinking and explore new possibilities for the "Wicked Cases" at hand.

Integrated Autonomy

Most of the challenges we face in the real world don't have an easy answer. Different solutions can be true or happen at the same time. This is also reflected in the 52 Scrum Master cases where multiple answers might be true. When discussing the cases, it's tempting to get stuck in either/or thinking. But what would happen when we start thinking in terms of 'and' instead of 'or'? What if we can find solutions that are helpful to both sides? Integrated Autonomy will help you adopt a more holistic view of the cases. Instead of steering the group in one direction of possible solutions, it actively invites them to uncover solutions that work across the field.

Improv Prototyping

The purpose of Improv Prototyping is to re-enact a challenging scenario (e.g. Scrum case) faced by a group or an individual and work together to devise different behavioral strategies and interventions by acting it out. The twist that this structure brings is that the person who introduced the scenario becomes the 'director', while the others become the 'actors'. This allows the director to playfully experiment with strategies, behaviors, and interventions. As such, Improv Prototyping is ideally suited to explore the Scrum cases!

What, So What, Now What?

'What, So What, Now What' is a foundational Liberating Structures that helps by asking us to step back and consider what is going on. It structures our thinking by breaking our experience down into three steps: "What do we notice?", "So, what does this mean?", and "Now, where do we go from here?". The flow of this Liberating Structure makes it ideally suited to reflect on the Scrum cases. Considering using 1-2-4-ALL to answer the questions. This prevents a group discussion and allows everyone to reflect and contribute.





Resources & Material

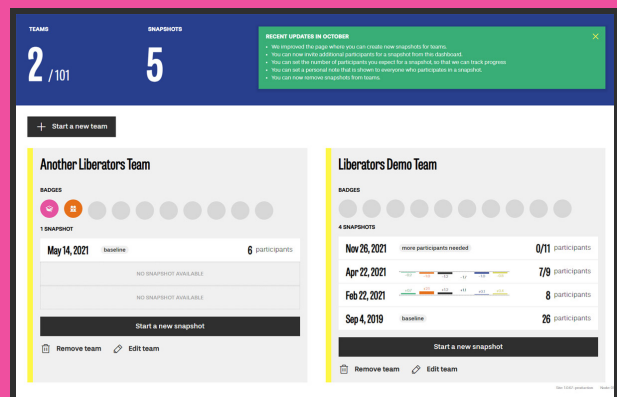
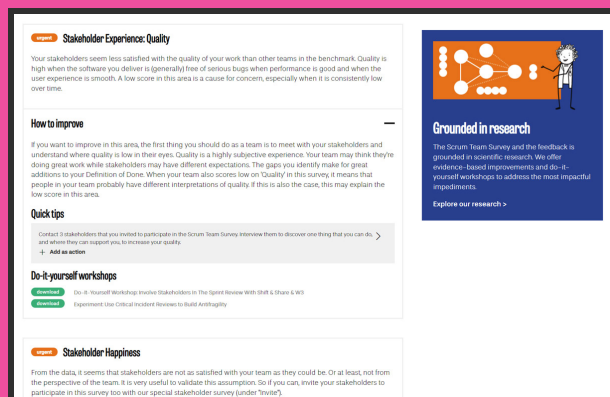
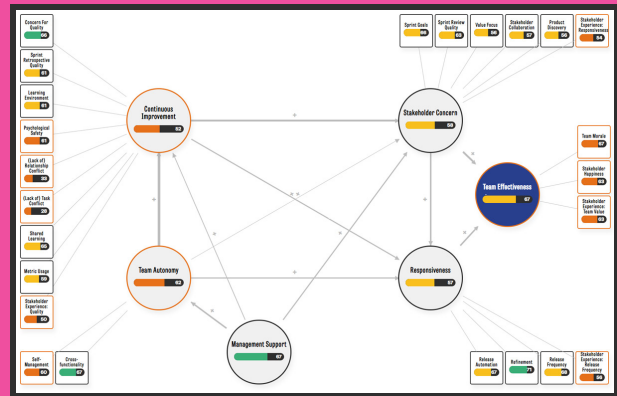
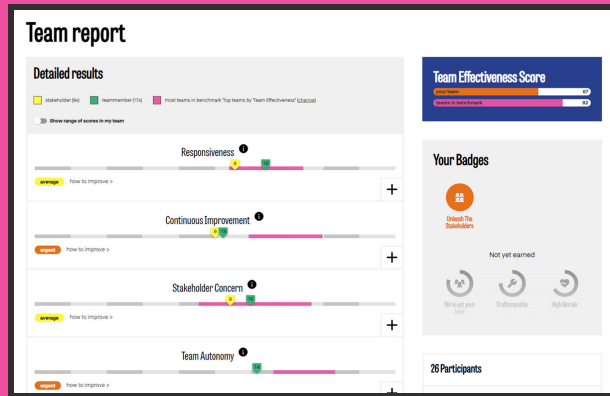


- Download the deck with [52 Scrum cases](#) in our webshop. The PDF comes with an English, Spanish, and Brazilian~Portuguese edition. The Spanish version is created by [Ulises Gonzalez](#), the Brazilian~Portuguese by [Carlos Padilha](#)
- Check out or on-going series of posts for [Scrum Mythbusters](#)
- Read [our whitepaper](#) where we explain the Scrum framework, and its principles and values, in our own words
- Download the free [Scrum framework poster](#) from our webshop and use it to discuss the Scrum cases



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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Unleashing Teams All Over The World

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